



Trailblazer: Swapnil Kusale secured India's first Olympic medal in the 50m 3 Positions, winning bronze after a stunning performance in the final.

RITU RAJ KONWAR

did she fall out of the top three places during the entire length of the competition. She eventually finished with 221.7 points and a bronze to hand India its first medal in the French capital.

Notably, she was only 0.1 points short of an assured silver medal! While that would have left many frustrated and disappointed, Manu had a big smile pasted on her lips when she waved to the crowd. She knew that the drought was finally over. It had taken India 12 years to bag a medal in the sport again after Vijay Kumar's silver in the men's 25m rapid fire pistol in London.

On July 29, she was at it again, trying to make the top four in the 10m air pistol mixed team event with Sarabjot Singh. Although Sarabjot dropped 11 points in his three series, a 291 from Manu was enough to see

the duo through to a bronze medal match against South Korea's Oh Ye Jin, an Asian Championship gold medallist, and Asian Games silver medallist Lee Wonho.

Lee and Ye Jin ended up shooting a lot of 9s in the final contest to concede a 16-10 defeat.

This victory saw Sarabjot heave a sigh of relief, with the shooter having missed out on a place in the 10m air pistol final three days prior after he shot one 'x' less than eighth-placed Robin Walter of Germany. This means Walter had hit an extra bullet in the inner-10 ring, the diameter of which is merely 5 mm. To put matters into perspective, the diameter of the graphite tip of a new wooden pencil, before being sharpened, is roughly the same!

With two medals in her bag, Manu had already entered her name in the history books. She became Independent India's first athlete to win two medals in a single edition of the Olympic Games. She also became only the second Indian female athlete to bag multiple Olympic medals after badminton sensation P.V. Sindhu.

Yet her undying passion for the sport would have told her she could push for the extra mile. Thus, with two of her events out of the way, Manu began preparations for the 25m sports pistol, which was still three days away.

On August 2, Manu proved difficult to catch as she raced away with the points in the Precision stage. By the time the curtains fell on Rapid,

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